

and feel of the network. Networks can offer photo uploading facility from sites like Flickr, and also from computers and mobile devices. Albums can be organised, photos tagged and Flash slideshows embedded. All these features come very handy for networks which are about photography. Networks created for video sharing have their own feature list to pick from. Video uploading can be done either directly or from sites that host videos, like YouTube. Here also Flash videos can be embedded. Most networks allows their members to change the look and feel of their profile pages. Ning has several themes of its own, and networks also typically create their own custom looks. They can put widgets on their profile pages. Members have a “chatterwall” where others can leave messages. They can also blog.

Friends can be added across networks. You don’t have to belong to the same network as your friend. Security features like controlling e-mail notifications and blocking users are default, with more privacy settings coming up. You can do a search of networks based on tags. Address books from other sites can be imported.

Ning has both its advantages and disadvantages. Individuals with a single id can browse across thousands of networks. No more boring signups and remembering passwords for each site you have joined. For site creators Ning does the backend part of setting up networks like hosting and maintaining users accounts, leaving the creators to innovate on the network. On the flip side the owners of the networks don’t have any say in advertising on their networks, nor do they have access to user data. To create really innovative layouts PHP programming knowledge is necessary, along with good CSS/HTML skills. That means the average Tom, Dick and Harry can create his own network, but it will not be much different from other sites.

2.9 www.meetup.com

Meetup is an example of glocalisation where information technologies like the Internet are used to provide local services on a global scale. The basic idea of Meetup is to convert all those online friend-